Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

We buy food with food stamps. If we don't have food stamps, we purchase with our bank card and we buy rice, flour, and halal meat, sometimes, it is not enough as there are seven of us.

a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

Our food stamps were cut off, and my husband was unemployed, which made it very difficult. When he had a job, we could buy food. We faced many problems, and we couldn't buy anything for our children. My husband was unemployed for nine months, and our food stamps were cut off several times, including once six months. We had to sign papers, but we didn't manage to do that. We experienced all these difficulties.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

God, his mercy is immense and provides sustenance. If we don't have food stamps, we still try to work and manage. We borrowed money to buy food and then worked to pay off the debts. But we are still in debt. Our relatives are here, and we borrowed money from them to buy food. Our food stamps are not enough especially when my husband was unemployed. We only have one person working, and my children are too young to work. I am also unwell and unable to work myself.

i. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

Our caseworker we are very grateful to them; they helped us in many ways they assisted with our rent, food stamps, and medical needs and we are happy with them.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

iii. Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

We didn't have money, but God's mercy is great. We contacted the food stamp office, and they helped us. Apart from that we worked and borrowed money. The issue became serious when our food stamps were cut off.

iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

c. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

When our food stamps were cut off. We borrowed money from our friend and then when my husband started working, we paid back.

2. The IRC assisted with our rent for 12 months, and our case is still being processed. They haven't helped with any financial or personal matters beyond that.

    i. Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

I didn't understand everything; my husband was the one handling all those matters.

    ii. You indicated that you have used the Snap program, can you tell me how you heard
    iii. about this program and how you applied for it?

It was IRC that applied for our food stamps. my husband knows everything, and we are going to DWS, so they take a translator for us and then they apply.

    iv. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

We feel good about having it, but the money isn't enough. When the money runs out, we buy things with our bank cards.

    v. Tell me about the food you received from them.

We buy from food stamps oil, flour, rice, and vegetables.

    vi. What % of your foods come from this program?

50%

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

We eat halal food from our own culture. We buy rice, oil, flour, biscuits, and halal meat from Costco and halal markets like WinCo and Rancho, we need whatever we need from these markets.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

It is important to eat from our culture flour is important oil is important, very important. In our culture, if you don't eat food, you can't survive. We don't buy bread from the markets we make it at home.

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

We get our vegetables from WinCo and Rancho.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

We had a case worker who would take my husband to get food because he didn't have a car at the time. They would help us buy our cultural foods. They would take us, and we would get the food ourselves.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

No, nothing is an obstacle.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

If a new immigrant arrives and doesn't have a job or lacks understanding, it can be challenging for them.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?
   If I can work or my daughter or my son can work, then we would not need IRC because we would be self-sufficient. However, since one person in our household is working, I am sick and my daughter is young and attending school, we need both Medicaid and food stamps.
4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

When we came here, we bought halal food, the same food we had in Afghanistan. I didn't understand the halal markets, so I would get our meat from the halal market and other items from different stores. I don’t know much about food stamps, but my husband understands everything. Since I’m sick and taking medication for my diabetes and high cholesterol, it’s tough. One worker supports six people, which is very hard. My children go to school, and thankfully, we have everything we need, but the difficulties mostly fall on my husband.